

Name: Tanishk Surana

Grade: 11th Grade

School: 10x International School, Bangalore

Company: Orangewood Labs

BuildUp Mediator Award - January 2026
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About the Company:

Orangewood Labs is a robotics startup focused on democratizing industrial automation through affordable, AI-powered robotic arms. Founded in 2017 and backed by Y Combinator, the company operates across the United States and India. Orangewood's flagship product, RoboGPT, enables users to program robotic arms using natural language, lowering the barrier to adoption for small and medium-sized businesses. The company aims to make automation accessible to non-technical users across industries such as food service, manufacturing, and industrial operations.

Project Overview:

The internship project focused on evaluating the market viability of multiple robotic use cases across food service and industrial domains. The objective was to determine which applications were commercially feasible, scalable, and strategically aligned with Orangewood's capabilities. Interns were tasked with developing differentiated go-to-market strategies for each use case by analyzing customer pain points, pricing dynamics, operational feasibility, and adoption readiness. The project culminated in a set of data-backed recommendations outlining whether each use case should be pursued, scaled, or paused, supported by market research, structured decision rules, and stakeholder validation.

Self Reflection:

Tanishk Surana entered the internship with a strong interest in understanding how early-stage, technology-driven companies make strategic decisions about where to compete and how to monetize innovation. His goals included learning how go-to-market strategy, pricing, and customer trust influence product direction, and contributing recommendations that would genuinely inform Orangewood's thinking about scaling robotic applications.

Throughout the internship, Tanishk demonstrated a highly analytical approach to the problem space. He developed skills in structured market analysis, framing strategic questions, and evaluating opportunities through a real-world business lens. A key learning for him was

understanding that a strong strategy is not about identifying impressive use cases, but about determining where customers will realistically pay, adopt, and sustain usage over time.

One of the main challenges Tanishk faced was working with incomplete company-specific data, particularly around financials, customer traction, and pricing power. He addressed this by combining careful analysis of the project memo with external industry reports, SME behavior patterns, and labor and cost dynamics to form well-reasoned hypotheses. Over time, he refined his thinking by converting qualitative insights into clear decision rules and pressure-testing assumptions through debate and iteration.

Through the internship, Tanishk developed the following skills:

- **Soft skills:** strategic communication, teamwork, ownership, accountability, and professional judgment
- **Hard skills:** market analysis, use case evaluation, GTM strategy development, assumption testing, and decision-rule formulation

The experience significantly deepened Tanishk's understanding of how startups translate technology into revenue and make disciplined choices under uncertainty. It reinforced his interest in strategy, business decision-making, and the commercial side of technology-driven ventures.

Peer Reflection:

Peer feedback consistently highlighted Tanishk as a reliable and supportive team member who took ownership of outcomes and contributed meaningfully to group progress. Team members noted his willingness to help others, offer thoughtful feedback, and engage constructively during discussions.

As the internship progressed, peers observed that Tanishk played a key role in strengthening the team's analytical rigor. He was particularly effective during moments of disagreement, helping transform differing opinions into structured debates that clarified assumptions and improved the quality of the final recommendations.

Peers highlighted the following strengths:

- Strong analytical thinking and structured problem decomposition
- Curiosity about business models and commercial viability
- Clear communication and collaborative mindset

- Reliability and consistency with deadlines and deliverables

Team milestones such as finalizing use cases and preparing touchpoint presentations were frequently cited as moments where Tanishk's contributions helped elevate both the clarity and defensibility of the team's work.

Mentor Highlights:

The mentor observed that Tanishk consistently demonstrated strong strategic thinking, maturity, and accountability throughout the internship. His ability to work with incomplete information while maintaining logical rigor was noted as a key strength, particularly in a startup and consulting-style environment.

Company representatives also responded positively to the clarity of the team's reasoning during touchpoints, with Tanishk's structured framing of questions and decision logic contributing to productive discussions. His approach reflected an understanding of buyer psychology, ROI considerations, and operational constraints faced by small and medium-sized businesses.

An area identified for continued development is gaining more direct exposure to real-world B2B customer interactions and sales cycles, which would further strengthen his commercial instincts. Overall, the mentor provided a strong endorsement of Tanishk's potential, highlighting his readiness to engage in complex strategic work and his ability to think like a decision-maker rather than solely an analyst.